

band, and this is when you let yourself be blown away by the AI—they sound like real cops having real conversations! They discuss how they're going to try to take you down, and are always chattering about your position. You start off at heat level 1, when you are just a naughty child to the cops. At this point, they're quite dumb and are as easily evaded as a short-sighted aunt. Bug them even more and you reach heat level 2. Then things finally start to get interesting—more cars will be on your tail now, and you will have to thunder through roadblocks to avoid getting busted. By heat level 5 you are being chased around by what seems to be every car on the planet, a helicopter, police Corvettes, and you've got to deal with spike-strips.

Sights And Sounds

NFS: Most Wanted is a brilliantly orchestrated assault on your senses. The environment and lighting is wonderful. Road reflections are incredible—you have the dry, diffused reflection of sunlight or a slicker, more glossy reflection when it's raining. Lighting is more realistic now, thanks to the new Overlighting effect—now, if you get out of a long tunnel, the sun actually blinds you for a split second while it simulates the effect of your eyes getting used to the light. If you reach a high enough speed, you can watch the environment start to blur around you, and pump some nitro into the engine to watch the world fleet by in an incoherent haze.

Of course, we mustn't forget the most important part of the game—the cars. The car models in *NFSMW* are sleek, shiny, and quite close to the real thing. There is a prolific selection of cars ranging from the humble (read: hopelessly weak) Chevrolet Cobalt to the awesome Lamborghini Murcielago. The engines sound awesome, and with a good set of speakers, you can almost feel the machine throbbing around you.

In keeping with the whole 'underground' theme, the soundtrack (delivered through EA's 'Trax' system) is a hip-hop/rock combination which we didn't like at all, but which suits the bling-filled attitude EA is trying to incorporate. Thankfully, this Trax pestilence can be traded in for regular music.

The Heart And Soul

At the core of it, after all, *NFSMW* is about racing, and you get plenty of it. To challenge each Blacklist racer, you need to win a number of races, and the challenge itself is usually two races. On top of that, there is the Free Roam mode, which has you zooming all over town avoiding cops. To start a new race, you have to

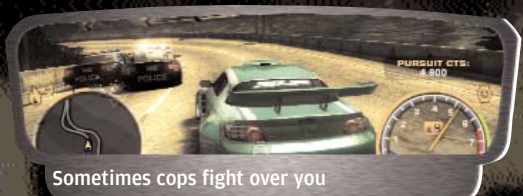
be out of the ever-watching eye of the fuzz, and as your heat level rises, this gets more difficult and hence frustrating.

The racing experience itself is unadulterated fun. The cars feel rock solid and are a joy for the compulsive powerslider. Little details like the shudder of a collision and the jump of gearshifts have been given due attention and do not disappoint. Freaks for realism will need to look elsewhere—this game is all about the adrenaline rush of full-throttle racing. Even car damage is practically non-existent—the most you'll ever see is a shattered windshield. This is not so for the police cars though, and you can have your fun watching turn into scrap metal.

Like so many other game developers, EA too has discovered the attractiveness of Bullet Time. Called the SpeedBreaker, this lets you stop time and try out new and dangerous manoeuvres like dodging the police by moving underneath trucks. If you are being excessively harassed by the Law, the game offers you Pursuit Breakers—structures across the city which you can destroy to keep them busy; the game camera switches to 'game moment cam' to show you just how much destruction you are leaving behind. This makes the game just that much more fun.

Even if the repetitiveness of racing about town and the eons it takes to finally complete the game are a pain, *NFS: Most Wanted* is a neatly packaged, well-styled bundle of fun. From hysterically bad acting to the pure thrill of racing, it is sure to be another winner. ☑

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Sometimes cops fight over you



Busted! We... uh... do this on purpose. To show you.



...and sometimes you need a ramp



We are brave



The gorgeous Gallardo



We try a "2Fast2Furious"



Better in Red

